

Outlook's default security settings: you can choose a different 'Secure Message Format' and specify which digital certificates you want to use. So what's all this about encryption, certificates, and digitally signing messages?

A digital certificate is like a stamp of authenticity. You can send digitally signed messages in Outlook by attaching a digital certificate. Whoever issues your digital certificate is vouching for you, saying that you are who you say you are. Digital certificates are, basically, special files issued by the certificate authorities such as VeriSign or your company's internal security administrator.

Under the 'Digital IDs (Certificates)' tab, click 'Import/Export' to import an existing 'Digital ID', if you have one, or to export your 'Digital ID' to file. If you don't have one, click 'Get a Digital ID'. You'll get to the Microsoft Office Web site, which will provide you with more information on how to get a 'Digital ID'.

Now, we come to sending and receiving encrypted e-mails. To do this, a recipient needs to have a copy of your digital certificate, and vice-versa. So how does your recipient get your digital certificate? You can send it in a message by attaching it as a file. But a better way to exchange digital certificates is to send each other digitally signed messages. To digitally sign a message (which is what happens by default when you check the 'Add digital signature...' checkbox), click 'Digitally Sign' on the toolbar on the message, as shown below. You can also, here, encrypt the message manually, which is a better policy than checking the 'Encrypt contents...' checkbox and having all messages encrypted by default.

When the recipient receives your message, he or she will need to add you to his or her 'Contacts'. This will also add the digital certificate. So when you are the recipient, you add the other person to your 'Contacts', and his or her digital certificate will be added, too. Now, the two of you can send and receive encrypted mails.